

Chapter 1: The Origins of Civilization

Week 1 · Brooks Vol. 1, Ch. 1 · HIS 101 — Prof. Swartz

Chapter Overview

Chapter 1 introduces civilization itself — not as a given, but as a set of specific technologies and social changes that emerged first in the Fertile Crescent of the Middle East around 9500 BCE. Brooks argues that civilization was not inevitable but rather the result of specific geographic advantages, particularly the availability of domesticable plants and animals in Mesopotamia. The chapter traces the long arc from the first experiments with agriculture to the rise of full urban city-states in Sumer by 3000 BCE, showing how surplus food enabled specialization, hierarchy, trade, writing, religion, and empire. Brooks frames Mesopotamia — not Greece — as the true origin point of Western Civilization.

Key Vocabulary and Definitions

Term	Definition
Civilization	A society characterized by agriculture, specialization, complex social hierarchy, cities, writing, and organized religion. Brooks defines it functionally — as specific technologies — not morally.
BCE / CE	Before Common Era / Common Era — secular replacements for BC/AD used by historians to avoid Christian-centric dating.
Fertile Crescent	Arc of land from present-day Israel through Lebanon, Syria, Turkey, and Iraq — the first region on Earth where agriculture was developed, beginning around 9500 BCE.
Mesopotamia	Greek for 'between the rivers' — the region between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers in modern-day Iraq. The cradle of Western civilization and the birthplace of cities, writing, and law.
Agriculture	The deliberate cultivation of crops and domestication of animals for food. The single most important invention enabling civilization — created food surpluses that allowed specialization.
Food Surplus	Producing more food than immediately needed. Enabled social specialization — people could become priests, soldiers, scribes, merchants — instead of everyone farming.
Social Specialization	The division of labor in which people perform different roles in society. Only possible when there is a food surplus to support non-farmers.
Domestication	The process of taming and selectively breeding wild animals and plants for human use. Sheep, goats, cattle, wheat, and barley were all first domesticated in the Fertile Crescent.

Term	Definition
Crop Rotation	Planting different crops in a field each year to restore soil nutrients, then letting it lie fallow periodically. Invented in the Fertile Crescent around 8000 BCE.
Plow	Tool that breaks up soil for planting, first used around 5000 BCE. Dramatically increased crop yields and the scale of agriculture.
Sumer	The southernmost region of Mesopotamia, home to the world's first true cities (including Uruk) beginning around 3500 BCE. Sumerians invented writing and the ziggurat.
Akkad	The northern region of Mesopotamia. The Akkadian language was Semitic (related to Arabic and Hebrew). Sargon of Akkad built the first true empire around 2334 BCE.
City-State	An independent city and its surrounding territory, governed as a single political unit. Mesopotamia was organized as competing city-states before empires emerged.
Redistributive Economy	An economic system in which a central authority (like a king or temple) collects all wealth and redistributes it. Used in Uruk to pay workers in food and beer.
Ziggurat	A massive stepped pyramid-temple at the center of every Mesopotamian city. Unlike Egyptian pyramids, ziggurats were temples — centers of worship, banking, and craft production.
Cuneiform	The first writing system, invented in Sumer around 3000 BCE to keep tax records. Started as pictographs, evolved into syllabic symbols pressed into clay tablets.
Pantheon	The complete set of gods worshipped by a culture. The Mesopotamian pantheon was shared across all cities, with each city also having a personal patron deity.
Divination	The practice of trying to predict the future through reading omens, entrails, or stars. Mesopotamian priests combined divination with astronomy — they saw little difference between magic and science.
Bureaucracy	A system of government through formal offices, rules, and records rather than personal relationships. Essential for governing large empires. The Ur III dynasty is an early example.
Hammurabi's Code	The most complete surviving law code from ancient Mesopotamia (~1780 BCE). Distinguished between classes (free men, commoners, slaves), protected women to a degree, and assigned specific punishments ('an eye for an eye').
Obsidian	Volcanic glass that could be chipped into extremely sharp tools. Çatal Höyük traded obsidian across hundreds of miles — proof of early long-distance trade networks.
Jericho	One of the world's earliest towns, located in Palestine, existing by ~8000 BCE. Shows that settlements preceded true cities by thousands of years.
Catal Hoyuk	Ancient town in Turkey (~7500 BCE). Archaeological evidence reveals early social inequality — some buried with wealth, others with nothing — and long-distance obsidian trade.

Important People

Person	Who Were They?	Why Do They Matter?
Enheduanna	Sumerian high priestess, daughter of Sargon of Akkad. High priestess of Inanna and Nanna in the city of Ur (~2300 BCE).	The first known author in history whose name survives. Wrote hymns to the gods, making her the earliest identified poet in recorded history.
Sargon of Akkad	King of Akkad (~2334–2279 BCE). Military conqueror who united the city-states of Mesopotamia under a single rule.	Creator of the world's first true empire. His empire showed that it was possible to rule over many cities — a new political model that later rulers would copy.
Ur-Nammu	King of the Ur III dynasty (~2112–2095 BCE). Conquered and re-unified Mesopotamia after the collapse of Sargon's empire.	Created one of the earliest complex bureaucratic systems in history — more efficient than Sargon's personal rule. His dynasty left more records than any other early Mesopotamian state.
Hammurabi	King of Babylon (~1792–1750 BCE). Conquered much of Mesopotamia and ruled from the city of Babylon.	Author of the most famous surviving ancient law code. Hammurabi's Code established formal legal distinctions between social classes and attempted to create systematic justice.
Gilgamesh	Legendary king of Uruk, protagonist of The Epic of Gilgamesh. Likely based on a real king, but the story is mythological.	Central figure of the world's oldest surviving work of literature. The epic explores mortality, friendship, and what makes a good leader — themes Brooks calls 'sophisticated and recognizable.'

Key Dates and Timeline

Date	Event
~9500 BCE	Agriculture first developed in the Fertile Crescent — the single most important invention enabling civilization.
~8000 BCE	Crop rotation invented in the Fertile Crescent. Town of Jericho (Palestine) established — one of the world's earliest settlements.
~7500 BCE	Town of Çatal Höyük (Turkey) established. Shows early social inequality and long-distance obsidian trade.
~5000 BCE	Plow invented in the Fertile Crescent. Egypt begins developing agriculture (adopted from the Fertile Crescent).
~4000 BCE	First cities begin emerging in Sumer, southern Mesopotamia.

Date	Event
~3500 BCE	Uruk becomes a major city (~50,000 people). First true urban society in the world. Long-distance trade networks reach India.
~3000 BCE	Fully urban civilization established in Mesopotamia — dozens of city-states. Cuneiform writing invented for tax records. Ziggurats built.
~2334 BCE	Sargon of Akkad conquers Mesopotamian city-states — creates the world's first empire.
~2112 BCE	Ur III dynasty founded. More sophisticated bureaucratic empire than Sargon's. Most records of any early Mesopotamian state.
~1792 BCE	Hammurabi becomes king of Babylon. Begins conquering Mesopotamia.
~1780 BCE	Hammurabi's Code written — the most complete surviving ancient law code.
~1595 BCE	Hittites defeat and sack Babylon, ending Hammurabi's empire.



Major Concepts to Know

Why Mesopotamia — Not Greece — Is the Origin of Western Civilization

Brooks opens with a deliberate challenge to the common assumption that Western Civilization starts with Greece. The concept of 'the West' is Greek-derived, but civilization itself began in Mesopotamia thousands of years before Athens existed. The Mesopotamians invented agriculture, cities, writing, mathematics, astronomy, engineering, and organized religion — the foundational technologies of civilization. Brooks wants students to understand that Greece built upon these older traditions, not that Greece invented them from scratch.

How Agriculture Transformed Human Society

Agriculture was not simply a smarter way to eat — it was a revolutionary reorganization of human life. By creating food surpluses, agriculture made it possible for some people to stop farming and develop specialized skills: priesthoods, armies, scribes, merchants, and rulers. This specialization created social hierarchies (rich and poor, rulers and ruled) and enabled the construction of cities, temples, and palaces. The evidence from Çatal Höyük — where some were buried with wealth and others with nothing — shows this inequality emerged almost immediately once food surpluses existed.

Why Cities Emerged: Water Management and Taxation

Brooks presents two complementary theories. First, managing the unpredictable floods of the Tigris and Euphrates required villages to cooperate on large-scale irrigation projects, which needed coordinating leadership — giving rise to governance. Second, cereal grains (wheat, barley) were easy to store and therefore easy to tax, incentivizing powerful groups to impose hierarchy and collect surplus. Cities were not simply bigger villages; they were the product of new systems of control, taxation, and labor.

The Redistributive Economy of Uruk

Uruk's economy was 'redistributive' — all economic activity was controlled by the central authority (the temple/palace), taxed, and then redistributed. Workers on public projects were paid in daily allotments of food and beer. This system required record-keeping, which is why writing was invented: not for poetry or religion, but for tax records. This is a key Brooks point — writing began as an accounting tool.

Mesopotamian Religion: The Gods Are Not on Your Side

Unlike later religions that emphasized divine love or protection, the Mesopotamians believed their gods were cruel, capricious, and easily offended. Humans were created to toil, not to be happy. The role of priests was primarily to beg the gods for mercy and prevent disasters. Every city had a patron deity who 'owned' it. This worldview shaped Mesopotamian culture — it helps explain their obsession with omens, divination, and the theme of human vulnerability in works like The Epic of Gilgamesh.

The Epic of Gilgamesh and the Human Condition

The Epic of Gilgamesh is the world's oldest surviving work of literature and a key primary source for understanding Mesopotamian values. Brooks highlights that the epic's central themes — what makes a good leader, the power of friendship, human frailty, and the unfairness of death — are 'sophisticated and recognizable' to modern readers. The epic shows that ancient peoples grappled with existential questions that we still ask today. On an exam, be prepared to explain what the epic reveals about Mesopotamian values and society.

Hammurabi's Code: Law as Political Tool

Hammurabi's Code (~1780 BCE) is more than a list of punishments — it is a political statement. By codifying law, Hammurabi claimed to be a just, benevolent ruler who looked after his subjects. The code distinguished sharply between social classes: the same crime carried different punishments depending on whether you were a free man, a commoner, or a slave. While famous for 'an eye for an eye' retributive justice, it also included protections for women and against unfair loans — more progressive in some ways than later legal codes.

Why Early Empires Were So Fragile

All of the early Mesopotamian empires — Sargon's, Ur III, and Hammurabi's — eventually collapsed. Brooks explains that their bureaucracies were too small to manage large populations, rebellions were frequent, and nomadic raiders from the Central Asian steppes (who had domesticated horses and fought from horseback) posed a threat that Mesopotamian armies could not effectively counter. Empires could conquer cities but struggled to hold them, creating a cycle of expansion, resentment, rebellion, and collapse.



Location	Why It Matters
Fertile Crescent	The arc of territory from modern Israel through Lebanon, Syria, Turkey, and Iraq where agriculture first developed (~9500 BCE). The starting point of Western Civilization.
Mesopotamia	The region 'between the rivers' (Tigris and Euphrates) in modern Iraq. Site of the world's first cities and the cradle of Western Civilization.
Sumer	Southern Mesopotamia. Home of the first true cities including Uruk. Where writing, ziggurats, and the Epic of Gilgamesh originated.
Akkad	Northern Mesopotamia. Region where Sargon built the first empire (~2334 BCE). The Akkadian language became the international language of the ancient Middle East.
Tigris & Euphrates	The two rivers that defined and enabled Mesopotamian civilization. Provided water and fertile soil but flooded unpredictably — driving the need for cooperative water management and governance.
Uruk	The first major city in the world (~3500 BCE, ~50,000 people). Center of early long-distance trade. Where the redistributive economy and cuneiform writing emerged.
Ur	City-state in Sumer; capital of the Ur III dynasty. Also the city where Enheduanna served as high priestess.
Jericho	Ancient Palestinian town (~8000 BCE). One of the earliest known human settlements — predates Mesopotamian cities by thousands of years.
Catal Hoyuk	Ancient town in Turkey (~7500 BCE). Archaeological evidence reveals early social inequality and long-distance obsidian trade networks.
Babylon	City in central Mesopotamia. Capital of Hammurabi's empire and the center of his famous law code.



Likely Essay and Discussion Topics

1. According to Brooks, why did civilization originate in Mesopotamia rather than somewhere else? What geographic and environmental factors made it possible?
2. How did the invention of agriculture transform human social organization? Use specific evidence from the chapter (Çatal Höyük, Uruk, etc.) to support your argument.
3. What does The Epic of Gilgamesh reveal about Mesopotamian values and beliefs? What does it tell us about how ancient peoples understood leadership, friendship, and mortality?
4. Compare Sargon of Akkad, Ur-Nammu, and Hammurabi as empire builders. What did each contribute to the development of large-scale political organization in Mesopotamia?



One-Paragraph Chapter Summary

Chapter 1 establishes that civilization — defined not morally but as a set of foundational technologies — began in Mesopotamia, specifically in the Fertile Crescent of the ancient Middle East, thousands of years before ancient Greece. The invention of agriculture around 9500 BCE created food surpluses, which enabled social specialization, hierarchy, and the growth of permanent settlements. By 3000 BCE, the southern Mesopotamian region of Sumer had produced the world's first true cities, including Uruk, organized around redistributive economies in which temples and palaces controlled all economic activity. These cities invented writing (cuneiform, originally for tax records), monumental architecture (ziggurats), astronomy, mathematics, and organized religion. Successive empires — Sargon of Akkad's conquest (~2334 BCE), the bureaucratic Ur III dynasty (~2112 BCE), and Hammurabi's Babylonian empire (~1792 BCE) — demonstrate an evolving but ultimately fragile experiment in large-scale political organization. The chapter closes by noting that while Mesopotamian civilization was not the only cradle of civilization globally (China and Mesoamerica developed independently), it was the origin point from which Western Civilization ultimately grew.